

REVIVAL OF FORTUNES

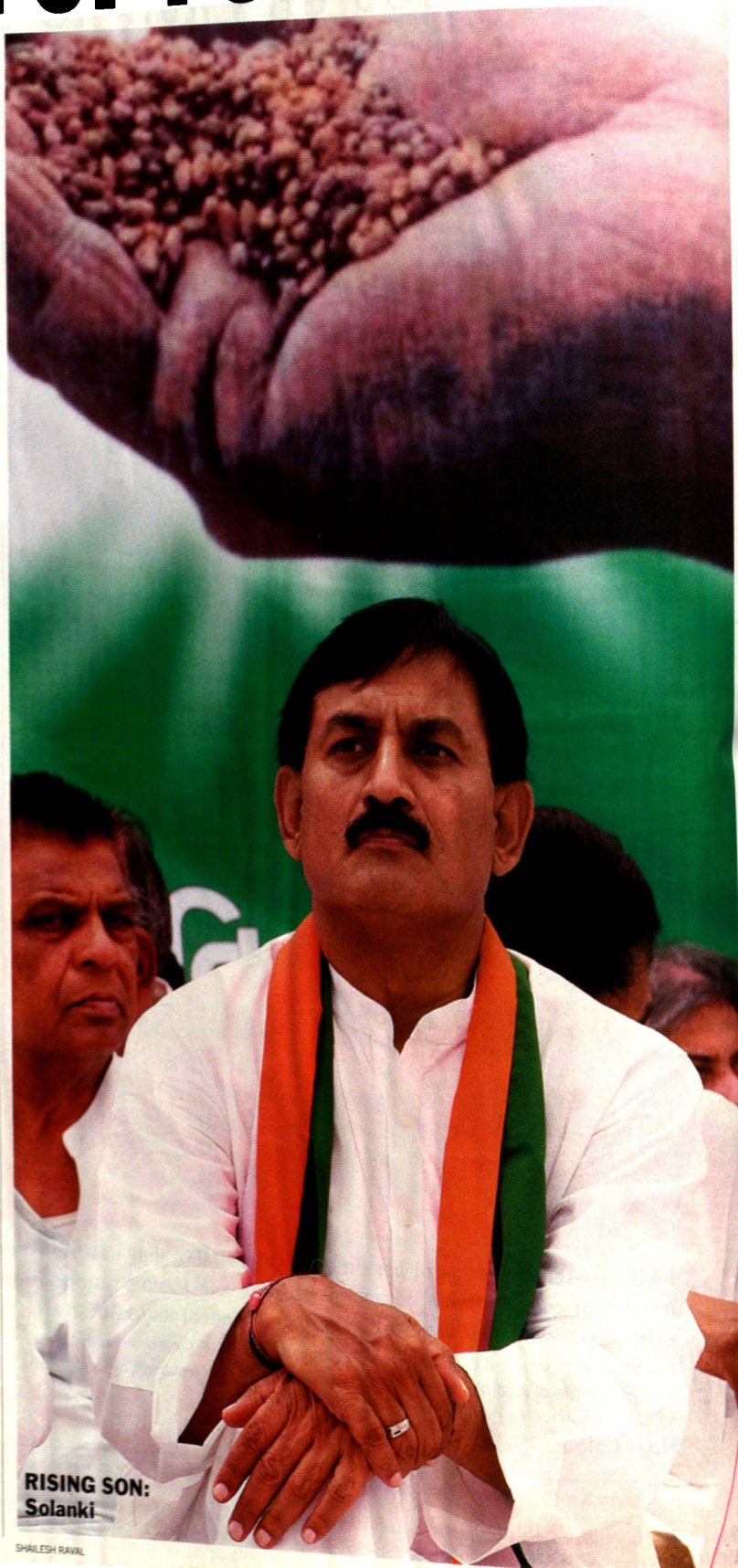
As the Congress gears itself to face the upcoming assembly elections, it has just found its knight in shining armour in the form of Bharat Solanki

■ By Uday Mahurkar

In the last Lok Sabha polls, when almost every pre-poll survey predicted the annihilation of the Congress, the state unit of the party was in the unenviable situation of not being able to find enough young leaders to contest the elections. There was, however, one exception—Bharat Solanki. Former chief minister Madhavsinh Solanki's son, he not only offered to contest but won the Anand seat by a margin of 61,000 votes despite Chief Minister Narendra Modi having addressed a number of rallies in the constituency.

Within two years of being appointed the state Congress president, Solanki has been able to transform a moribund Congress into a well-oiled political machine with help from party bigwigs like Ahmed Patel, Shankarsinh Vaghela, Arjun Modhawadia, Narhari Amin, Shaktisinh Gohil and Siddharth Patel. The average Congress worker is now looking forward to the polls with an enthusiasm that hadn't been seen in the past decade.

Under Solanki, the Congress's recovery started last December when he organised the first training camp at Ambaji for 750 party workers. These workers were selected from around 2,500 applicants on the basis of merit. Called the Janmitra Shivar, the camp was aimed at widening the party's base and showing it as people-friendly. The camp had a psychiatrist and experts from various fields, who gave the workers lessons in the history of the party, human relations, team building and time management. This was done with a view to bringing about a transformation in the manner in which the Congress workers had been



RISING SON:
Solanki

SHARLESH RAWAL